that fencing is a temporary measure but says it could last up to five years, until the species settles down. To which experts argue that since cheetahs are short-lived carnivores, a five-year period in a fenced area amounts to life imprisonment.

The decline of the prey base in Kuno is another matter of concern, as the MP forest department's own report observes. It shows that chital density has reduced from 23.43 animals per sq. km in 2021 to 17.5 in 2024. The prey base was one of the main reasons Kuno was chosen over other sites. "There is a huge deficit of prey in Kuno," the report states. "Prey augmentation has to be carried out immediately. At least 1,500 chital have to be brought to increase ungulate prey base."

CONSERVATIONISTS VS POLITICIANS

The frequent deaths of the large cats not only kicked up a storm of concern over maintaining the population but also an unsavoury war of words between the biologists and government officials anchoring the project, as well as politicians. Among the criticisms was that the mortalities could have been avoided if international experts had been consulted as India's expertise on cheetahs is limited. A monitoring committee appointed by the Supreme Court in 2020 to guide the NTCA was abruptly dissolved in March 2023. This was speculated to be a reaction to the criticism aired by several experts following the deaths of six cheetahs, including three cubs, in about 80 days. The CPSC did not include veterans such as Ranjitsinh and Jhala who had prepared the detailed CAP. "Soon after the cheetahs arrived, our committee began working and would hold regular meetings. A few months later, I learnt through media reports that a Cheetah Task Force had been constituted, but we continued working. In March, the Union government informed the Supreme Court that the expert committee was not needed," says Ranjitsinh.

International experts such as Adrian Tordiffe, one of the foremost cheetah experts, and Vincent van der Merwe, manager, Cheetah Metapopulation Project, were retained as consultants. However, in July 2023, four international experts, including Tordiffe and van der Merwe, wrote to the apex court that they were not being consulted and that this was affecting conservation efforts.

In August 2024, the MP forest department's refusal to share records of the cheetah project under the Right to Information Act, citing potential harm to the country's sovereignty and integrity, elicited further concerns from the biologist community about the project's management.

There is inter-state politics too. Among the second homes being considered for cheetahs was Mukundara Hills in Rajasthan. The WII had selected it as the best breeding site, due to its 82 sq. km fenced area and adequate prey base. The MP government had asked the Centre to consider shifting some cheetahs there, but the latter did not consider it. Reports suggested that the Congress government in power in Rajasthan at the time was the reason for this reluctance, while some said a Rajasthan politician was not too keen to share Mukundara Hills—envisaged originally as a home for tigers—with the imported spotted cats. Thus, Gandhi Sagar's 64 sq. km was fenced at a steep cost of Rs 17 crore and an entire village, Karnpura, was relocated. Yet, officials now confirm that some leopards have entered the enclosure through the water route (one side of the boundary is a reservoir), which may remain a source of threat for the cheetahs.

Meanwhile, Palpur's hopes to be a cheetah tourist destination lie dashed, as the success of the cheetah conservation project itself is moot. "Room occupancy at my resort is down to 10-15 per cent, which I manage because I am located on the highway. Two other resorts that opened in 2022 have shut down," says Jinesh Jain, owner of Jungle Resort Kuno. Forest authorities opened safaris last year but the area where the cheetahs are housed is not open for visitors. "Earlier when there were no cheetahs, we had guests coming in to see other wildlife. This helped us get business. Now that business is lost too," adds Jain. The revival of that economy will need a better cheetah action plan. ■



BHUPENDER YADAV
Union Minister of Environment, Forest and Climate Change

"The project has seen unprecedented success in births of cubs in comparison to similar projects in other countries... initial years of any reintroduction/ conservation translocation projects will undergo ebbs as well as flows before stabilising

The cheetahs were intermittently free ranging. They were brought back into the enclosures for specific health reasons and veterinary treatment. The enclosures are large natural forested areas with wild prey which the cheetahs hunt themselves, like in the wild

As a first step towards metapopulation management through a large landscape approach, including the landscapes of Kuno and Gandhi Sagar in Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and possibly Uttar Pradesh, an interstate cheetah conservation complex is being developed"